The Hollywood Plate

What the Slim, Strong Stars Really Eat After 65, and a Four-Week Menu to Eat Like Them

From the Behind the Fame YouTube channel

Please read this first

This book is for information and enjoyment. It is not medical advice. If you have diabetes, kidney disease, heart disease, high blood pressure, trouble swallowing, or take prescription medicines, especially blood thinners, please show the menu to your doctor or a registered dietitian before you change how you eat. Some foods interact with medicines. Nothing here replaces that conversation.

The recipes are written in our own words for an ordinary American kitchen. The stories of what the stars ate come

from their own cookbooks, memoirs, interviews and the recollections of their families.

Welcome

Sophia Loren has eaten pasta nearly every day of her life and has worn the same dress size for sixty years.

Audrey Hepburn, the most imitated figure of the twentieth century, lived on spaghetti with tomato sauce and a square of dark chocolate after dinner.

Julia Child cooked with butter for fifty years on television and lived to ninety-one. Her secret, she said, was not what she ate. It was how much.

Betty White ate hot dogs. Dolly Parton eats “a little of everything.” Jane Fonda eats more protein at eighty-eight than she did at forty, on purpose. Martha Stewart drinks a glass of green every morning before she goes out to the garden. And Clint Eastwood, at ninety-five, still eats the

same plain plate of salmon and vegetables that has kept him on a film set for seventy years.

None of these people were on a diet. That is the whole point of this book.

If you are over sixty-five, you have probably been on a dozen diets. Grapefruit. Cabbage soup. Low-fat. Low-carb. Points. Shakes. Most of them worked for a month and then the weight came back, and each time a little of your strength went with it. And now your doctor says the numbers are creeping up, your clothes feel different than they did at fifty, and you are tired by three in the afternoon.

Here is what the stars in this book understood, some of them from their grandmothers and some of them the hard way. After sixty-five, the rules change. You need *more* protein, not less. You need to keep muscle, because muscle is what keeps you out of the hospital. Crash diets strip muscle first. The way to lose the weight that arrived after menopause, and keep your strength, is to eat the way

Sophia Loren eats: real food, a small plate, every day, with pleasure.

This book has two halves.

Part One sits you down at the tables of eight stars and shows you what was actually on the plate. Each chapter tells the story, explains what a doctor would say about it today, and gives you their dishes, rewritten for a woman cooking for one or two in an American kitchen. Twenty-six recipes, most of them twenty minutes, none of them hard.

Part Two turns those dishes into a gentle four-week menu, with a shopping list for every week, a pantry list, and a chapter on how to lose weight after sixty-five without losing your strength. If you only want to be told what to eat tomorrow, start there.

At the back you will find the recipes listed by occasion: Sunday with the grandchildren, a quiet supper for one, something to bring to church.

Pull up a chair. Sophia is already at the table.

The Behind the Fame team

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Part One: The Stars’ Plates

Chapter 1. Sophia Loren: Pasta every day

In 1998, at the age of sixty-four, Sophia Loren published a cookbook.

It was not a diet book, and it was not a glamour book with photographs of her in a kitchen she had never used. It was a book of the recipes her grandmother had cooked in Pozzuoli, the poor town outside Naples where Sophia grew up during the war, when there was often nothing to eat at all. Pasta with beans. Pasta with tomatoes. Soups made from whatever was in the garden. Fish from the bay, when there was money for fish. A little cheese, a little bread, fruit.

She wrote it, she said, because people kept asking her how she stayed slim, and the honest answer was that she had

been eating the same way since she was five years old.

Here is what that looks like. Sophia Loren eats pasta almost every day. But her plate of pasta would disappoint an American restaurant. It is a small plate, about a cup, dressed with olive oil, tomatoes, garlic, basil, and perhaps a handful of beans or a few shrimp. It is one course of a meal, not the whole meal. After it comes a salad or a cooked vegetable, dressed with oil and lemon. Then fruit. A glass of wine with dinner. Bread, but only good bread, and not much of it.

She does not snack. She does not drink soda. She does not eat standing up. She sits down, and she stops when she is satisfied, not when she is full. In Pozzuoli, she has said, nobody could afford to be full, and the habit stayed with her for life.

There is one more Loren rule, and she is firm about it: she has never been on a diet. “A diet is a punishment,” she has said. “I do not punish myself.” When she needs to be slimmer for a film, she eats the same foods and slightly

less of them, and she walks more. That is the entire program.

In 2020, at eighty-six, she came back to the screen in *The Life Ahead*, and the cameras found a woman who looked the way she had always looked: strong, upright, unmistakably herself. She was walking before dawn every morning of the shoot, and she was eating pasta every day of it.

What a doctor would say today

Sophia Loren was raised on the diet that medicine has spent forty years trying to recommend: the **Mediterranean diet**. Olive oil instead of butter. Vegetables, beans, and whole grains at the center of the plate. Fish more often than meat. Fruit instead of dessert. Wine in moderation, with food. The largest studies ever done on older adults found that people who eat this way have fewer heart attacks and strokes, better memory, and less diabetes. There is nothing exotic about it. Her grandmother cooked it because it was cheap.

The portion is the secret, not the pasta. A cup of cooked pasta has about two hundred calories and is a perfectly good food. The American problem is the three-cup plate, the cream sauce, and the garlic bread beside it. Make the pasta one small course, add beans or fish for protein, and follow it with vegetables, and you are eating like Sophia.

Beans are the quiet hero. Pasta e fagioli, pasta with beans, is one of the oldest dishes in Italy and one of the best things a woman over sixty-five can eat. Beans are cheap, full of protein and fiber, keep blood sugar steady, and keep you full for hours.

“Satisfied, not full” is a real tool. It takes about twenty minutes for your stomach to tell your brain that it has had enough. Eating slowly, sitting down, with a pause halfway through, lets that message arrive before the second helping.

Sophia’s table

Spaghetti al pomodoro for two

The dish she has eaten most often in her life. Twenty minutes.

- 4 ounces dry spaghetti (a bundle the width of a quarter)
- 2 tablespoons olive oil
- 2 cloves garlic, sliced
- 1 can (14 ounces) crushed tomatoes, or 4 ripe tomatoes, chopped
- A pinch of salt, a pinch of sugar if the tomatoes are sharp
- A handful of fresh basil, torn, or 1 teaspoon dried
- 2 tablespoons grated Parmesan

Boil the spaghetti in salted water until just tender. While it cooks, warm the oil in a skillet over medium heat and cook the garlic until it smells good, about one minute, without browning. Add the tomatoes and salt, and simmer ten minutes until thick. Drain the pasta, keeping a little of the water. Toss the pasta in the sauce with a splash of the pasta

water and the basil. Serve with the cheese. About 300 calories and 10 grams of protein per plate. Add a can of drained white beans to the sauce for 8 more grams.

Pasta e fagioli (pasta with beans) for two, with leftovers

The dish of her childhood, and a complete meal in one bowl.

- 2 tablespoons olive oil
- 1 small onion, 1 carrot and 1 stalk celery, chopped small
- 2 cloves garlic, chopped
- 1 can (14 ounces) diced tomatoes
- 1 can (15 ounces) cannellini or white beans, drained
- 3 cups low-sodium chicken or vegetable broth
- 1 teaspoon dried rosemary or Italian seasoning
- ¾ cup small pasta (ditalini, small shells, or broken spaghetti)
- Salt and pepper, Parmesan to serve

Warm the oil in a pot and cook the onion, carrot and celery until soft, about eight minutes. Add the garlic for one minute. Add the tomatoes, beans, broth and rosemary, bring to a boil, and simmer fifteen minutes. Add the pasta and cook until tender, about ten minutes more, adding water if it gets too thick. Season. Serve with a spoon of cheese and a drizzle of oil. Keeps three days in the refrigerator and freezes well. About 380 calories and 16 grams of protein per bowl.

The Neapolitan salad for one

What follows the pasta on Sophia’s table.

Tear a few leaves of romaine or butter lettuce into a bowl. Add a sliced tomato, a few slices of cucumber, a few olives, and a quarter of a red onion, very thinly sliced. Dress with one tablespoon of olive oil, a squeeze of lemon, salt and pepper. Add a hard-boiled egg or two ounces of canned tuna to make it a meal.

Baked fish with tomatoes and olives for two

The way fish is cooked all along the bay of Naples. Twenty minutes, one pan.

Heat the oven to 400°F. Lay two fillets of white fish (cod, tilapia, haddock, about 5 ounces each) in a baking dish. Scatter over a cup of cherry tomatoes, halved, a handful of olives, two cloves of sliced garlic, and a few capers if you have them. Drizzle with two tablespoons of olive oil, season with salt, pepper and oregano. Bake fifteen to eighteen minutes until the fish flakes. Serve with a slice of good bread to mop up the juices. About 280 calories and 28 grams of protein.

Chapter 2. Audrey Hepburn: Spaghetti, a garden, and one square of chocolate

Audrey Hepburn’s son, Luca Dotti, grew up thinking his mother was an ordinary Swiss housewife who happened to have an Oscar in a cupboard.

She lived the last thirty years of her life in a farmhouse called La Paisible, “the peaceful one,” in a village above Lake Geneva. She had a vegetable garden she worked herself, in gloves, on her knees. She had dogs. She walked

to the village to buy bread. And, according to Luca, who wrote a book about her kitchen after she died, she cooked the same handful of dishes over and over, and the one she loved most in the world was spaghetti al pomodoro. Spaghetti with tomato sauce. On a Sunday night, with her family, that was happiness.

People find this hard to believe. Audrey Hepburn was, for sixty years, the picture that every woman was told to look like. Surely she lived on lettuce leaves and air.

She did not. And the reason is a story that explains almost everything about how she ate.

In the winter of 1944, Audrey was fifteen years old and living in the occupied Netherlands. The Germans had cut off food to the western cities, and the Dutch call that winter the Hunger Winter. People ate tulip bulbs. Audrey later said that she made flour from them. She was so malnourished by the spring of 1945 that she developed anemia, swollen legs, and breathing problems, and she believed for the rest of her life that the damage to her body from that year was why she stayed so thin. When the

Allied trucks arrived with food, she ate so much that she was sick.

So Audrey Hepburn was never on a diet. She had been starved once, and she never wanted to feel it again. What she did instead was eat simply, in small amounts, all day, without fuss. Breakfast was bread and jam, or an egg. Lunch was often a salad from the garden with a piece of cheese. Dinner was pasta, or a vegetable soup, or a piece of chicken with vegetables. She ate very little meat. She ate a great deal of vegetables, most of them from her own ground. And after dinner, every single night, she had one square of good dark chocolate. Not the bar. One square.

Her other habit was movement that did not look like exercise. She gardened. She walked the dogs. She walked to the village. She did not own a treadmill. She did own a very good pair of boots.

She died in 1993, at sixty-three, of a rare cancer that had nothing to do with how she lived. But her son’s memory of her kitchen is worth more than a thousand diet books. The

most elegant woman of her century ate spaghetti, grew tomatoes, and finished the day with a square of chocolate.

What a doctor would say today

Vegetables from the garden, or from a bag, are the single biggest change most American plates need. Audrey ate them at every meal, usually more than anything else. The current advice for older adults is at least two and a half cups a day, and most women over sixty-five eat about half that. It is not a matter of salad. Soups, roasted trays, vegetables stirred into eggs and pasta, frozen vegetables steamed in the microwave, all count.

Small amounts, often, is a good pattern after 65. Appetite shrinks with age, and many older women eat one large meal and skip the rest. Audrey's way, three modest meals and nothing in between except perhaps fruit, keeps blood sugar steady and makes sure you get enough protein across the day instead of all at dinner.

One square of chocolate is not a sin. Dark chocolate, seventy percent cocoa or more, in an amount the size of a postage stamp, has been linked in large studies to slightly

lower blood pressure and heart risk. The trouble with chocolate is the bar, not the square. The trick is to buy good chocolate, which you will not want to gobble, and to make it the last thing you eat each night, so that there is nothing to want afterward.

Hunger is not a virtue. Audrey's body carried the marks of one year of starvation for fifty more years. Crash diets, in a milder way, do the same. Never let yourself get truly hungry; it leads to the second helping and the midnight toast.

Audrey's table

Her spaghetti al pomodoro

Audrey's version, as her son remembers it, was even simpler than Sophia's: tomatoes cooked slowly with a little onion and olive oil, pasta, basil, cheese. Use the recipe in Chapter 1 and, in Audrey's way, add a finely chopped half onion to the oil before the garlic and let the sauce simmer twenty minutes instead of ten. She served it with a green salad and nothing else. She had, by her son's account, a modest portion and a glass of wine.

Garden vegetable soup for one, with leftovers

What she ate most on ordinary days. Thirty minutes. It is also the soup to make when you have vegetables going soft.

- 1 tablespoon olive oil
- 1 onion, 2 carrots, 2 stalks celery, chopped
- 1 zucchini and 1 potato, chopped
- 1 can (14 ounces) diced tomatoes
- 4 cups low-sodium broth
- 1 cup green beans, fresh or frozen, cut up
- 1 can (15 ounces) white beans or chickpeas, drained
- A handful of spinach or chopped cabbage
- Salt, pepper, a teaspoon of dried thyme, Parmesan to serve

Cook the onion, carrots and celery in the oil until soft. Add everything else except the spinach and beans, bring to a boil, and simmer twenty minutes. Add the beans and spinach for the last five. Season. Serve with cheese and a slice of bread. Makes four bowls. About 220 calories and

11 grams of protein per bowl. Freeze the rest in single portions.

The La Paisible lunch

A plate, not a recipe. A handful of lettuce or whatever greens you have. A sliced tomato. A boiled egg, or a slice of cheese, or a few slices of cold chicken. A piece of good bread. A piece of fruit. Olive oil and lemon over the greens. Eaten sitting down, at the table, with the radio on.

Chicken with lemon and herbs for two

Her one meat dish, for Sundays. Forty minutes, mostly in the oven.

Heat the oven to 400°F. Put two chicken thighs, skin on, or two breasts, in a baking dish. Rub with a tablespoon of olive oil, salt, pepper, and a teaspoon of dried rosemary or thyme. Squeeze a lemon over them and put the squeezed halves in the dish. Scatter a cup of baby potatoes, halved, and a sliced onion around the chicken, and toss them in the juices. Roast thirty-five to forty minutes until the chicken is golden and the potatoes are tender. Serve with green

beans or a salad. About 420 calories and 32 grams of protein with the potatoes.

The square of chocolate

Buy a bar of dark chocolate, 70 percent cocoa or higher. Break it into squares and keep it in a tin, not the wrapper. One square after dinner, let it melt, do not chew. That is dessert. Audrey said so.

Chapter 3. Julia Child: Butter, small helpings, and ninety-one years

Julia Child taught America to cook with butter.

For nearly forty years on public television, a six-foot-two woman with a voice like a happy foghorn stood in a kitchen and dropped sticks of butter into pans, whipped cream into sauces, and told a nation that had been raised on margarine and canned soup that food was supposed to taste good. She was asked, constantly, how she could eat like that and live. She lived to ninety-one. She died two days before her ninety-second birthday, in 2004, having eaten a bowl of French onion soup the night before.

So what was the trick?

She gave the answer so many times that her friends could recite it. “Small helpings. No seconds. No snacking. A little bit of everything.” And, when pressed: “Everything in moderation, including moderation.” She meant it. People who ate at her table remember that she served real food, rich food, in surprisingly modest amounts, and that she ate slowly, talking, and finished before anyone else noticed she had stopped.

She also did something that would horrify a modern diet book. She refused to be afraid of food. She thought fear was the real problem with the American table: fear of fat, fear of eggs, fear of bread, fear that led people to eat sad, joyless, processed substitutes in large quantities instead of real, delicious things in small ones. “If you’re afraid of butter,” she said, “use cream.”

Here is what Julia actually ate on an ordinary day in her later years, according to her assistants. Breakfast was an egg, or toast, with coffee. Lunch was often a sandwich or a salad. Dinner was a proper meal, one course, with

vegetables, and a glass of wine. She almost never ate dessert at home. She loved a good hamburger. She hated the word “diet” and never used it.

And she stayed on her feet. She cooked, which is harder work than it looks, until she was in her late eighties. She walked. She traveled. At ninety she was still demonstrating omelets on television, cracking eggs with one hand.

What a doctor would say today

Julia Child was right about more than she knew.

Fat does not make you fat; too much food makes you fat. After forty years of low-fat advice, the research came in, and it turned out that people who replaced fat with sugar and refined starch got heavier and sicker, not thinner. Olive oil, butter in small amounts, eggs, nuts, cheese, and fatty fish are all back on the table. What matters is the total amount on the plate and what else is on it.

Eggs are nearly perfect food for a woman over 65. For decades we were told to limit them. Today’s guidelines say an egg a day is fine for most people, and for older adults

they are one of the cheapest, easiest sources of high-quality protein there is. An omelet, Julia's signature, takes three minutes and delivers twelve grams of protein. Two eggs at breakfast change the whole day.

"No seconds" is the single most useful rule in this book. Serve the plate, eat it slowly, and do not go back. Put the leftovers away before you sit down, if the pot on the stove tempts you.

Pleasure keeps you eating. This matters more than it sounds. Many women over seventy slowly stop eating properly because food has become joyless: cooking for one, bland low-salt meals, fear of everything. Undereating is more dangerous than overeating at that age. Julia's answer was to make the small plate delicious.

Julia's table

The three-minute omelet for one

Her most famous demonstration, and the best breakfast in this book.

Beat two eggs with a pinch of salt and pepper and a teaspoon of water. Melt a teaspoon of butter in a small nonstick skillet over medium-high heat until it foams. Pour in the eggs. Let them set for about ten seconds, then stir gently with a fork while shaking the pan, until they are mostly set but still a little wet on top. Stop stirring. Add a tablespoon of grated cheese, or some cooked spinach, or herbs. Tilt the pan and fold the omelet over on itself as you slide it onto the plate. Serve with a slice of whole-grain toast and sliced tomato. About 280 calories and 16 grams of protein with the cheese and toast.

Potage parmentier (leek and potato soup) for four

The first recipe in her first book, and still the simplest good soup there is.

- 3 leeks, white and light green parts, sliced and rinsed well, or 1 large onion
- 3 medium potatoes, peeled and diced
- 4 cups water or low-sodium chicken broth
- 1 teaspoon salt
- 2 tablespoons butter or ¼ cup milk, to finish

- Chopped parsley or chives

Simmer the leeks and potatoes in the water with the salt, partly covered, for about forty minutes until very tender. Mash with a potato masher or blend until smooth. Stir in the butter or milk off the heat. Taste for salt. Serve with the herbs. Julia added cream for guests; for every day she did not. About 160 calories per bowl. Add a boiled egg on the side or a slice of ham for protein.

Roast chicken, the Sunday one

Heat the oven to 425°F. Pat a whole chicken (about 4 pounds) dry. Rub inside and out with a tablespoon of soft butter or olive oil, salt and pepper, and put a halved lemon and a few sprigs of thyme inside. Put it breast up in a roasting pan and roast about an hour and fifteen minutes, until the juices run clear when you pierce the thigh. Let it rest fifteen minutes before carving. Serve with roasted vegetables and a green salad. Keep the carcass for broth. A four-pound chicken gives four generous servings plus sandwiches for the week. A 4-ounce portion of roast chicken is about 220 calories and 30 grams of protein.

Julia’s simple green salad and vinaigrette

In a jar, shake together 3 tablespoons olive oil, 1 tablespoon wine vinegar or lemon juice, ½ teaspoon Dijon mustard, a pinch of salt and pepper. Keeps a week in the refrigerator. Dress washed, dried lettuce at the last moment, with just enough to coat, never a puddle. She served salad after the main course, which slows the meal down and fills you with greens.

The Julia rule for hamburgers

She loved a hamburger. Hers was a 4-ounce patty of good ground beef, cooked in a hot pan with salt and pepper, on a bun, with lettuce and tomato, and nothing fried beside it. One. No seconds. Enjoyed.

Chapter 4. Jane Fonda: Why she eats more protein at eighty-eight than she did at forty

In the 1980s, Jane Fonda sold twenty million exercise videos and ate almost nothing.

She has written about it with a frankness that still startles people. From her teens into her forties she was bulimic, bingeing and purging in secret, sometimes several times a day, while she filmed movies and won Oscars and told American women how to feel the burn. “I was not a healthy person,” she wrote. “I was obsessed with being thin.” The workout empire, she admitted, was built partly on an illness.

Then, in her late forties, she stopped. She got help. And over the next forty years she did something that very few women of her generation managed: she learned to eat for strength instead of for size.

Here is what that means at eighty-eight, in her own words from interviews and from her book on the “third act” of life, *Prime Time*. “I eat more protein now than I ever did.” Fish, chicken, eggs, beans, Greek yogurt, at every meal. Because, she explains, she learned from her doctors that the muscle she needs to stay upright, to get out of a chair, to not break a hip, is made of protein, and after sixty the body needs more of it, not less, to hold on to that muscle.

She eats a great deal of vegetables, “half the plate.” She eats fruit, nuts, and whole grains. She does not eat much sugar, and she says plainly that she feels the difference when she does. In her eighties she stopped drinking alcohol because, she said, it affects an older body far more than a younger one and she wanted her sleep back.

What she does not do is diet. “I’ve done that,” she has said. “It nearly killed me.” She eats three real meals. She eats breakfast, which she skipped for decades. She keeps protein bars in her purse for long days on set. And she lifts weights, slowly, a few times a week, so that the protein has somewhere to go.

Two cancer diagnoses, a hip replacement, a knee replacement, and eighty-eight years in, Jane Fonda is stronger than she was in the leotard. She would be the first to tell you that the leotard was never the point.

What a doctor would say today

Jane Fonda’s doctors told her something that most women over sixty-five are never told clearly, and it is the most important sentence in this book:

After 65, you need more protein than you did at 40. The standard advice for younger adults is about 0.36 grams of protein per pound of body weight. Researchers who study aging now recommend about 0.45 to 0.55 grams per pound for people over sixty-five, and more if you are ill or recovering from surgery. For a woman who weighs 150 pounds, that is roughly 70 to 80 grams a day. Most older American women eat about 50, and much of it at dinner.

Spread it across the day. Your body can only use about 25 to 30 grams at a time to build muscle. A breakfast of toast and coffee, a lunch of soup, and a dinner with a big piece of chicken wastes most of the chicken. Aim for 25 grams at each meal. In food, that is:

- 2 eggs plus a cup of Greek yogurt, or
- A 3-to-4-ounce piece of fish, chicken, or lean meat (the size of your palm), or
- A cup of cottage cheese, or
- A cup of beans or lentils plus a slice of cheese, or
- A cup of Greek yogurt with a handful of nuts.

Muscle is what keeps you independent. The protein only works if you ask the muscle to grow: a few minutes of strength work with soup cans and a chair, as in our first book, two or three times a week. Protein plus movement is the combination that study after study finds keeps women out of nursing homes.

Sugar and alcohol hit an older body harder. Blood sugar swings are larger, sleep is lighter, and both are tied to memory. Fonda's choice to cut them was not vanity.

Jane's table

The Greek yogurt breakfast bowl for one

Her most common breakfast, and the easiest 25 grams of protein in this book. Two minutes.

A cup of plain Greek yogurt (2 percent or whole milk, which keeps you full longer). A handful of berries, fresh or frozen. A tablespoon of chopped walnuts or almonds. A spoon of ground flaxseed if you have it. A drizzle of honey only if you must. About 250 calories and 22 grams of protein. Add a boiled egg on the side for 28.

Salmon with greens for two

Her standard dinner. Fifteen minutes.

Heat the oven to 425°F. Put two salmon fillets (5 ounces each) on a foil-lined pan, skin down. Brush with a teaspoon of olive oil, season with salt, pepper, and a squeeze of lemon. Roast twelve minutes. Meanwhile, warm a tablespoon of olive oil in a skillet, add a clove of sliced garlic and a big bag of spinach or chopped kale, and cook until wilted, two or three minutes. Season. Serve the salmon on the greens with lemon. About 350 calories and 32 grams of protein. Canned salmon, drained and mashed with a little lemon and a spoon of yogurt, is the budget version and just as good for you.

Red lentil soup for four

Lentils are the cheapest protein in the supermarket and cook in twenty minutes. This is a Fonda lunch.

- 1 tablespoon olive oil
- 1 onion and 2 carrots, chopped
- 2 cloves garlic, chopped

- 1 teaspoon ground cumin, ½ teaspoon turmeric if you have it
- 1 cup red lentils, rinsed
- 1 can (14 ounces) diced tomatoes
- 4 cups low-sodium broth
- Juice of half a lemon, salt and pepper

Cook the onion and carrots in the oil until soft. Add the garlic and spices for one minute. Add the lentils, tomatoes and broth. Simmer twenty minutes until the lentils collapse. Blend part of it if you like it smooth. Add the lemon, taste for salt. About 230 calories and 14 grams of protein per bowl. Top with a spoon of Greek yogurt for 18.

Cottage cheese plate for one

Her on-set lunch. A cup of cottage cheese, sliced tomato and cucumber, black pepper, a few crackers or a slice of whole-grain bread, a piece of fruit. About 300 calories and 28 grams of protein. Cottage cheese is the most underused food in the American refrigerator for women over sixty-five.

Chicken and vegetable sheet pan for two, with leftovers

The dinner she makes when she wants to cook once and eat twice. Thirty-five minutes.

Heat the oven to 425°F. On a large sheet pan, toss two chicken breasts or four thighs with two cups of chopped vegetables (broccoli, bell pepper, red onion, zucchini, cherry tomatoes), two tablespoons of olive oil, salt, pepper, and a teaspoon of dried oregano or Italian seasoning. Spread out in one layer. Roast twenty-five to thirty minutes. Serve half tonight with a scoop of brown rice or a slice of bread. Chop the rest cold into tomorrow’s salad. About 380 calories and 35 grams of protein.

Chapter 5. Betty White: Hot dogs, French fries, and the rule that made them harmless

When reporters asked Betty White what she ate, she enjoyed the look on their faces.

Hot dogs. French fries. Red Vines licorice, by the bag. A vodka on the rocks, with a lemon, in the evening. “I don’t have a diet,” she said at eighty-nine. “I eat whatever I want.” She lived to ninety-nine, working until the end, and she was telling the truth.

But here is what the reporters did not write down, because it was not funny.

Betty White ate *one* hot dog. She ate a *small* order of fries. She had *one* vodka. She was, by every account of the people who worked with her for sixty years, a light eater who did not think about food very much at all. She never dieted and she never overate, because food was neither her enemy nor her comfort. It was lunch, and lunch was over quickly, because she had a crossword to finish and a scene to shoot.

She was also, for a woman who claimed to live on junk, surprisingly regular about three things. She ate breakfast. She did not snack through the evening in front of the television; she went to bed early and got up early. And she was never still. She lived for decades in a two-story house

and said, only half joking, that the stairs were her gym: “I have a two-story house and a very bad memory, so I’m up and down those stairs all day.”

When she was in her nineties and could no longer manage the stairs the same way, her assistant cooked for her, and the menu, by his account, was simple: eggs, chicken, soup, vegetables, the occasional hot dog, the nightly vodka. She weighed about what she had weighed on *The Golden Girls* thirty years earlier.

The Betty White lesson is not “eat hot dogs.” It is this: a woman who eats small, regular meals of plain food, keeps moving, and refuses to make food a drama can get away with almost anything, including the occasional hot dog, for a hundred years.

What a doctor would say today

Being slightly heavy after 65 is not the danger. Being frail is. This surprises people. In adults over sixty-five, people whose weight sits a little above the charts live longer, on average, than people who are underweight, and unintentional weight loss is one of the strongest warning

signs a doctor looks for. Crash diets strip away muscle first. Betty White never crash-dieted, and she never lost her strength.

The portion is the whole story with “bad” foods. A hot dog has about 150 calories. Three hot dogs with chili and a pile of fries have a thousand. A small handful of licorice is a treat; a bag is a meal. Betty’s “whatever I want” came in portions the size of her hand.

Do not snack after dinner. Most of the extra calories an older woman eats arrive between seven and eleven at night, in front of the television, without hunger. Betty’s early bedtime removed those hours entirely. If you must have something, make it Audrey’s square of chocolate or a cup of herbal tea, and make the kitchen closed after that.

Keep it plain. Eggs, chicken, soup, vegetables. Betty’s real menu was almost boring, and that is why it worked. Simple food is easy to cook for one, easy to portion, and hard to overeat.

Betty’s table

The Betty hot dog night, done right

Once a week, if you like it. One good-quality hot dog, grilled or boiled, on a whole-wheat bun, with mustard, onions and sauerkraut (which is a vegetable). Beside it, not fries but a big spoon of coleslaw made with a vinegar dressing, or a sliced tomato with salt. About 350 calories. One. Enjoy every bite.

Oven fries for two

When only fries will do. Heat the oven to 425°F. Cut two medium potatoes, skin on, into wedges. Toss with a tablespoon of olive oil, salt, pepper and paprika. Spread on a sheet pan and bake twenty-five minutes, turning once, until golden. About 180 calories a serving, and not fried in anything.

Scrambled eggs with vegetables for one

Her assistant’s breakfast for her. Beat two eggs. Cook a handful of chopped tomato, spinach, or leftover vegetables in a teaspoon of butter or oil for one minute. Add the eggs,

stir gently over medium-low heat until just set. Salt and pepper. Toast on the side. About 230 calories and 14 grams of protein.

Chicken soup, the real one, for six

The soup to keep in the freezer for every week of the menu.

Put a whole chicken, or 2 pounds of thighs, in a big pot with 2 chopped onions, 3 carrots, 3 stalks of celery, 2 cloves garlic, a bay leaf, a teaspoon of salt, and water to cover by two inches. Bring to a boil, skim the foam, and simmer gently for an hour and a half. Lift out the chicken, pull the meat off the bones in bite-size pieces, and return the meat to the pot. Add a cup of egg noodles or rice and cook ten minutes. Add a handful of chopped parsley or frozen peas. Taste for salt. About 250 calories and 22 grams of protein per bowl. Freeze in single portions.

The Betty vodka, and the honest rule about drinks

One drink, in the evening, with dinner, if your doctor has no objection and you take no medicine it would interfere with. Vodka with soda and lemon is about 100 calories. A

glass of wine is about 120. Mixed drinks and sweet cocktails are 250 and up. After sixty-five, alcohol hits harder, disturbs sleep more, and raises the risk of falls, so one is the number, and some nights none. Betty had one, and went to bed.

Chapter 6. Martha Stewart: The green glass, the garden, and the swimsuit at eighty-one

Every morning at six, before she looks at a phone or a newspaper, Martha Stewart stands in her kitchen and drinks a tall glass of something green.

She has described it so many times that fans make it along with her. A big handful of spinach. A few stalks of celery. Half a cucumber. A piece of fresh ginger. Some parsley. A little fresh orange or apple to take the edge off. Through the juicer, into a glass, drunk standing up. Then she puts on her boots and goes outside.

She was eighty-one when *Sports Illustrated* put her on the cover of its swimsuit issue, and the first question everyone

asked was what diet she had gone on. She had gone on none. “I didn’t starve myself,” she said. “I ate what I usually eat.” What she usually eats, it turns out, is one of the most sensible plates in this book, because most of it comes out of her own dirt.

Martha Stewart has a working farm, and she works it. Her vegetables are her vegetables. Her eggs come from her chickens. She eats a great deal of fish and very little red meat. Lunch is often a big salad with an egg or some fish on it. Dinner is fish or chicken with whatever the garden gave her that day. She drinks a lot of water and a little wine. She is wary of sugar and almost never eats candy or soda, which is a striking thing for a woman who has built an empire on cakes.

About the cakes: she eats them. A slice, on the day she makes one. She has said, more than once, that moderation is not deprivation, and that the person who bans dessert ends up eating a box of cookies at midnight.

The green juice gets the headlines, but the garden is the secret. A woman who spends two hours a day planting,

weeding, pruning and hauling is doing more exercise than most gym members, and she is eating what she grows, which means her plate is mostly vegetables without her having to think about it.

What a doctor would say today

Leafy greens may be the single best food for an aging brain. A long study in Chicago that followed nearly a thousand older adults found that those who ate about one serving a day of greens, spinach, kale, collards, lettuce, had brains that worked as if they were eleven years younger than those who rarely ate them. One serving. A handful in your eggs, a salad at lunch, spinach stirred into soup.

Juice is good; the whole vegetable is better. A juicer throws away the fiber, which is what keeps you full, keeps your bowels regular, and keeps blood sugar steady. A blender keeps it. If you want Martha's morning glass, make it a smoothie, or simply eat the salad.

Gardening is a prescription. Older adults who garden have lower rates of heart disease, better hand strength,

better bone density, less depression, and in some studies lower rates of dementia. It gets you into the sunlight that sets your sleep clock and makes vitamin D. A few pots on a porch will do.

Sugar is the thing to be suspicious of, not fat. Added sugar in sodas, sweetened coffee, cereal, flavored yogurt, and “healthy” granola bars raises blood sugar and feeds inflammation, and is tied to heart disease and memory loss. The daily sweet tea does more damage than Martha’s monthly slice of cake.

Martha’s table

The morning green smoothie for one

Her juice, with the fiber kept in. Three minutes in a blender.

A big handful of spinach or kale. Half a cucumber, chopped. A stalk of celery. A small piece of fresh ginger, peeled. Half an apple or a small orange, peeled. A cup of water or unsweetened almond milk. Blend until smooth. For a breakfast that holds you until lunch, add half a cup of

plain Greek yogurt or a scoop of protein powder; that turns 90 calories into 200 with 15 grams of protein.

The big lunch salad for one

What she eats most days. Fill a wide bowl with greens: romaine, spinach, arugula, whatever you have. Add a cup of chopped vegetables: cucumber, tomato, bell pepper, carrot, radish. Add your protein: two boiled eggs, or a can of tuna or salmon, or a cup of chickpeas, or leftover chicken. Add something crunchy: a tablespoon of sunflower seeds or walnuts. Dress with Julia’s vinaigrette. A slice of whole-grain bread on the side. About 400 calories and 25 to 30 grams of protein depending on the protein.

The roasted vegetable tray

Make this on Sunday and eat from it all week. Heat the oven to 425°F. Cut into chunks any three or four of: sweet potato, carrots, beets, Brussels sprouts, cauliflower, broccoli, red onion, bell peppers, zucchini. Toss with two tablespoons of olive oil, salt, pepper, and a teaspoon of dried herbs. Spread on two sheet pans and roast thirty to

forty minutes until browned at the edges. Keep in the refrigerator. Add to eggs, salads, soups, grain bowls, or eat cold with a spoon of hummus.

Baked eggs in a nest of greens for one

Her chicken-and-garden breakfast. Wilt two big handfuls of spinach or chard in a small ovenproof skillet with a teaspoon of olive oil and a clove of garlic. Make two hollows in the greens and crack an egg into each. Season. Bake at 375°F for ten to twelve minutes until the whites are set. Eat with toast. About 220 calories and 14 grams of protein.

Lemon fish in a packet for two

The simplest fish dinner in the world, no smell, no mess. Heat the oven to 400°F. Tear two squares of foil or parchment. On each, put a 5-ounce fillet of white fish, a few thin slices of lemon, a handful of thinly sliced zucchini or asparagus, a teaspoon of olive oil, salt, pepper and a few sprigs of dill or parsley. Fold the packet closed. Bake fifteen minutes. Open at the table. About 220 calories and 28 grams of protein.

A slice of cake, the Martha way

Bake it yourself, on a Sunday, when the grandchildren are coming. Eat one slice, with them, at the table. Send the rest home with them.

Chapter 7. Dolly Parton: “A little of everything,” and the banana pudding

Dolly Parton grew up one of twelve children in a one-room cabin in the Smoky Mountains of Tennessee, and she will tell you, if you ask, that she still eats like it.

Not the quantity. The food. Beans and cornbread. Chicken and dumplings. Greens cooked with a piece of fatback. Fried okra. Biscuits and gravy. Banana pudding. The food of a poor Southern family in the 1950s, where a chicken fed fourteen people and nothing was wasted. She has published a cookbook of it, and she has said that the smell of cornbread in a skillet takes her straight back to her mother’s stove.

So how does a woman who loves biscuits and gravy stay, at eighty, the size she was at twenty-five?

Her answer has not changed in fifty years. “I eat a little of everything and not a lot of anything.”

Watch what she means. At a table with a dozen dishes on it, Dolly takes a spoonful of each. A bite of the dumplings. A small square of cornbread. A spoon of beans. A taste of the pudding. She has said that she cannot stand the thought of giving anything up, so she gives up nothing, and takes a little. She does not go back for more. “I’ve never been on a diet in my life that I stayed on past lunch.”

She eats breakfast very early, because she wakes at three. She has said that she often eats her main meal at midday and something light at night. She loves “a good tomato sandwich” in summer, which is sliced tomato on white bread with mayonnaise, salt and pepper, and she is not sorry.

And then there is the banana pudding. It is her most famous recipe, the one her fans make, the one she has put her name on. Vanilla wafers, sliced bananas, vanilla

custard, and a meringue or whipped topping. It is pure comfort and pure sugar, and she eats it, a small bowl, on a Sunday, with the people she loves.

Dolly Parton's plate is the opposite of a diet book. It is a Southern table with every indulgence on it, eaten in spoonfuls, with joy, early in the day, and finished with a little bowl of pudding and no guilt whatsoever.

What a doctor would say today

"A little of everything" is better than "none of some things." Studies of people who keep weight off for years find one thing in common: they do not ban foods. Bans end in binges. A spoonful of the real thing, eaten at the table, satisfies the craving that a "sugar-free" substitute only sharpens.

Beans, greens and cornbread are a very good meal. Underneath the fatback, the Southern table is built on beans (protein and fiber), greens (the best food for your brain, see the last chapter), sweet potatoes, tomatoes, and corn. Cooked with less salt pork and more olive oil, it is as healthy as anything in Italy.

A big lunch and a light supper suits an older body. Blood sugar is handled better earlier in the day. Many people over sixty-five sleep better after a light evening meal, and the habit cuts down on the after-dinner snacking that adds the most weight.

Watch the salt. The one real problem with traditional Southern cooking is sodium: the ham hock, the bacon grease, the canned vegetables, the seasoning salt. High blood pressure is nearly universal after sixty-five, and salt is the lever. Use a smoked turkey wing instead of fatback, rinse canned beans, and season with vinegar, pepper, onion and herbs.

Dolly’s table

Skillet cornbread

Heat the oven to 425°F with a 9-inch cast iron skillet or baking pan inside. Mix 1 cup cornmeal, ½ cup flour, 1 tablespoon sugar (optional), 2 teaspoons baking powder, ½ teaspoon salt. Beat in 1 egg, 1 cup buttermilk or milk with a squeeze of lemon, and 2 tablespoons melted butter or oil. Take the hot pan out, swirl a teaspoon of oil in it, pour in

the batter, and bake twenty minutes until golden. Cut into eight. About 150 calories a wedge.

Pinto beans with greens, the lighter Monday pot, for four

- 2 cans (15 ounces each) pinto beans, rinsed, or 2 cups cooked dried beans
- 1 onion, chopped
- 1 tablespoon olive oil
- 1 smoked turkey wing or 2 slices turkey bacon, chopped (optional)
- 3 cups low-sodium broth
- 1 bunch collard greens or kale, stems removed, chopped
- A splash of cider vinegar, black pepper, hot sauce

Cook the onion in the oil until soft. Add the turkey, beans and broth, and simmer twenty minutes. Add the greens and cook ten minutes more until tender. Finish with vinegar and pepper. Serve with a wedge of cornbread. About 280

calories and 15 grams of protein per bowl. Add a sliced boiled egg or two ounces of chopped ham for a full 25.

Chicken and dumplings, Sunday pot, for six

Make Betty’s chicken soup from Chapter 5, without the noodles. When the soup is ready and the chicken is back in the pot, mix 1½ cups flour, 2 teaspoons baking powder, ½ teaspoon salt, 2 tablespoons butter cut in, and ¾ cup milk into a soft dough. Drop it by spoonfuls onto the simmering soup, cover, and cook fifteen minutes without lifting the lid. Serve with black pepper. About 340 calories and 24 grams of protein per bowl.

The tomato sandwich

In August, when the tomatoes are good. Two slices of bread, a tablespoon of mayonnaise, thick slices of a ripe tomato, salt and pepper. Dolly uses white bread. Whole wheat is fine. Eat it over the sink.

Dolly’s banana pudding, the lighter Sunday version, for six

- 1 package (about 3 ounces) instant vanilla pudding, sugar-free if you like
- 2 cups cold milk (2 percent)
- 1 cup plain Greek yogurt
- 1 teaspoon vanilla
- 3 ripe bananas, sliced
- About 30 vanilla wafers
- 1 cup whipped topping or whipped cream

Whisk the pudding mix with the milk for two minutes. Whisk in the yogurt and vanilla. In a bowl, layer wafers, bananas and pudding, twice. Top with the whipped cream. Chill at least two hours. Serve a small bowl, Dolly-size. About 210 calories and 6 grams of protein a serving, roughly half of the traditional version, and the grandchildren will not notice.

Chapter 8. Clint Eastwood: The plainest plate in Hollywood, at ninety-five

This chapter is for your husband, if you have one, and for you if you don’t.

Clint Eastwood was ninety-one when he directed and starred in *Cry Macho*, riding a horse on screen. He was ninety-four when he finished his next film. He was born in 1930, in the first year of the Depression, and he is, as far as anyone can tell, the oldest working director in the history of the movies. He walks onto a set at seven in the morning, works a full day, and goes home to a plate of food that would bore most people to tears.

That plate, by his own description and that of the people who have cooked for him, is this: a piece of salmon or other fish, or occasionally chicken. A big pile of vegetables. Some fruit. Nuts. Green tea. Water. No soda, no sugar, no fried food, no desserts, no bread to speak of, and, for most of his adult life, very little red meat.

He is not preachy about it. He says, simply, that he feels better when he eats that way, that he has eaten that way for decades, and that he does not see the point of eating things that make him tired. “I just try to eat right,” he said once. “Salmon, vegetables, fruit.”

He has a few other habits worth knowing. He has meditated twice a day since the 1970s, which he credits with keeping his blood pressure down and his temper even. He does not drink much. He plays golf and walks the course. And he has a philosophy about aging that he once summed up in a story about his friend Toby Keith. Keith asked him how he kept going at eighty-eight. Eastwood said: “I get up every day and I don’t let the old man in.” Keith wrote a song with that title.

The Eastwood plate is the simplest in this book and, by the numbers, probably the healthiest. Fish, vegetables, fruit, nuts, tea, water. It is also the one most men over seventy will refuse, because it has no bread, no beer, and no dessert. Which is why it comes at the end of Part One, with the others as the gentler road to the same place.

What a doctor would say today

Fatty fish twice a week is one of the best-proven habits for an aging heart and brain. Salmon, sardines, mackerel, trout and herring carry omega-3 fats that lower the risk of heart rhythm problems, stroke and, in some studies, dementia. Canned salmon and sardines are cheap and just as good as fresh.

The plate with no sugar is the plate that prevents diabetes. More than a quarter of Americans over sixty-five have type 2 diabetes, and another half are on the way to it. Eastwood's plate, fish, vegetables, fruit, nuts, is close to the diet that every diabetes doctor recommends, and it keeps blood sugar flat all day.

Green tea and water, instead of soda and juice, removes the easiest hundreds of calories in the American diet. A can of soda is about 150 calories and 10 teaspoons of sugar. One a day, for a year, is fifteen pounds.

Men over 70 need this chapter more than women do. Men are less likely to see a doctor, more likely to be overweight around the middle, which is the dangerous

kind, and more likely to have a heart attack. If the man in your house eats what is on this page three nights a week, you have done more for him than any nagging will.

Meditation lowers blood pressure. Eastwood's twenty minutes, twice a day, is more than most people will do. Five minutes of quiet breathing once a day, as in our first book, is enough to measure a difference.

Clint's table

Salmon, vegetables, and nothing else, for two

Season two 5-ounce salmon fillets with salt, pepper and lemon. Cook in a hot skillet with a teaspoon of olive oil, skin side down, for four minutes, then turn and cook three more. Serve with steamed broccoli, green beans or asparagus, dressed with olive oil and lemon. A small baked sweet potato beside it if you want a starch. About 380 calories and 34 grams of protein with the sweet potato.

Sardines on toast for one

The cheapest brain food in the store. Mash a can of sardines in olive oil with a squeeze of lemon, black pepper,

and a little chopped onion or parsley. Pile on a slice of whole-grain toast. Sliced tomato on the side. About 300 calories and 22 grams of protein.

The big vegetable stir-fry for two

A tablespoon of oil in a hot wide pan. A clove of garlic and a teaspoon of grated ginger for thirty seconds. Four cups of mixed chopped vegetables, fresh or a bag of frozen stir-fry mix. Cook over high heat, stirring, five minutes. Add a cup of cooked chicken, shrimp, or a block of firm tofu cut in cubes, and two tablespoons of low-sodium soy sauce. Two minutes more. Serve over a half cup of brown rice each. About 380 calories and 28 grams of protein with chicken.

Fruit and nuts, the Eastwood dessert

An apple or an orange, and a small handful (about twelve) of almonds or walnuts. About 200 calories, 5 grams of protein, and it keeps blood sugar flat until the next meal. This is also the right afternoon snack for the whole menu.

Green tea

Steep a bag three minutes in water that has stopped boiling. Two or three cups a day, in place of soda, sweetened coffee or juice. If caffeine bothers your sleep, decaffeinated green tea keeps most of the benefit.

Part Two: Eat Like Them

Chapter 9. The five rules of the Hollywood plate after 65

Eight stars, eight very different tables, and underneath them the same five rules. Here they are in one place. If you remember nothing else from this book, remember these.

Rule 1. Protein at every meal, the size of your palm

Jane Fonda’s rule, and the one that matters most after sixty-five. Each of your three meals should carry about 25 grams of protein: two eggs and yogurt at breakfast, fish or beans or cottage cheese at lunch, a palm-sized piece of chicken, fish or meat at dinner. Without it, the body quietly eats its own muscle, and muscle is what keeps you out of the hospital. A quick reference:

Food	Protein
1 egg	6 g
1 cup Greek yogurt	20 g
1 cup cottage cheese	25 g
3 ounces chicken, fish or lean meat	22 to 26 g
1 can tuna or salmon	25 to 30 g
1 cup cooked beans or lentils	15 to 18 g
1 ounce cheese	7 g
1 cup milk	8 g
2 tablespoons peanut butter	8 g
1 small handful of nuts	5 to 6 g

Rule 2. Half the plate is vegetables

Audrey’s rule, and Martha’s. Look at your dinner plate. Half of it should be vegetables: salad, roasted tray, steamed greens, soup, a stir-fry. The other half is split between your protein and a small portion of starch: a cup of pasta, a scoop of rice, a potato, a slice of good bread. Frozen vegetables count. Canned, rinsed, count. A bag of spinach stirred into anything counts.

Rule 3. The small plate, no seconds

Sophia’s rule, and Julia’s. Use a nine-inch plate, not a twelve. Serve once. Put the pot away before you sit down. Eat slowly, at the table, and stop when you are satisfied, not full. Twenty minutes is how long it takes your stomach to tell your brain. If you are still hungry twenty minutes after the meal, have a piece of fruit.

Rule 4. A little of everything, not none of some things

Dolly’s rule, and Betty’s. Do not ban foods. Bans end in binges at eleven at night. Have the real cornbread, the real pudding, the hot dog, the slice of cake, in a small portion, at the table, on a day you choose, and enjoy it completely. Then the kitchen is closed.

Rule 5. Nothing sweet to drink, and nothing after dinner

Clint’s rule, and Betty’s early bedtime. Water, tea, coffee, milk, and one glass of wine or one drink if your doctor allows. No soda, no sweetened coffee drinks, no juice as a

beverage. And after dinner, one square of chocolate or a cup of herbal tea, and the kitchen is closed. The hours between seven and eleven at night are where the weight comes from.

The plate, drawn

Picture a nine-inch plate divided like a clock. From twelve to six, vegetables. From six to nine, your protein. From nine to twelve, your starch. A glass of water beside it. A piece of fruit after. That is lunch and dinner for the rest of your life, and it is also exactly what Sophia Loren's grandmother served in 1940.

Chapter 10. Losing weight after 65 without losing your strength

Here is a conversation many women have had with a doctor.

"You should lose some weight."

"How?"

“Eat less and move more.”

And then nothing. No menu, no warning that the usual way of losing weight is actually dangerous after sixty-five, no mention that half of what you lose on a crash diet is muscle, not fat. So here is the chapter the doctor did not have time for.

Why the old way fails after 65

When a younger woman cuts her food in half, she loses fat and some muscle. When a woman over sixty-five does it, she loses fat and a great deal of muscle, because her body is already losing muscle every year and the diet speeds it up. She ends the diet lighter but weaker: less able to climb stairs, more likely to fall, slower to recover from illness. Then the weight comes back as fat, and she is worse off than before. Doctors see it constantly.

The research is clear on what works instead, and it is almost exactly what the stars in Part One do.

The gentle way, in five steps

1. Decide whether you need to. Being ten or fifteen pounds over the chart after sixty-five is not dangerous and may be protective. What matters is where the weight sits (around the middle is worse than on the hips), whether your blood sugar and blood pressure are good, and whether you can move. If your doctor says the numbers are fine and you can climb a flight of stairs, you may not need to lose anything. Ask.

2. Keep protein high while eating less of everything else. This is the whole trick. Cut the starch, the sugar, the snacks, the drinks, the portions. Do not cut the eggs, fish, chicken, beans, yogurt and cheese. Aim for your 25 grams at every meal, even on the days you eat less. Studies of older adults who lose weight this way keep almost all their muscle.

3. Lift something. Two or three times a week, the soup-can routine from our first book, or any strength class at the senior center. This tells your body to keep the muscle and burn the fat. Walking is wonderful for your heart, but it does not protect muscle the way lifting does. Both.

4. Slow is the speed. Half a pound to one pound a week. Not more. Faster than that is muscle going. At that speed, fifteen pounds takes four to six months. That sounds slow until you remember that every diet you did faster than that came back.

5. Eat the Hollywood plate. Protein at every meal, half the plate vegetables, small plate, no seconds, nothing sweet to drink, kitchen closed after dinner. The menu in the next chapter does this for you.

Where the weight actually comes from

Most women are surprised when they write down everything they eat for three days. The meals are usually fine. The weight comes from:

- Sweet drinks, including juice, sweetened coffee, and “a little” soda
- The evening hours in front of the television
- Portions that have grown over years without anyone noticing

- “Healthy” packaged foods: granola bars, flavored yogurt, cereal, crackers
- Eating standing up, from the pot, while cooking
- Skipping breakfast and then eating too much at four in the afternoon

Fix those six things and most women lose weight without changing dinner at all.

Three warnings

Do not skip meals. It leads to the four o’clock binge and it starves muscle.

Do not go below about 1,200 calories a day without a doctor watching. Older women who eat too little lose bone, lose muscle, get dizzy, fall, and get sick more often.

If you are losing weight without trying, stop reading this chapter and call your doctor. Unintentional weight loss after sixty-five is a warning sign, not good news.

Chapter 11. The four-week menu

Four weeks of the Hollywood plate, built from the recipes in Part One. The portions are for one; double everything for two. Each day gives you about 1,400 to 1,600 calories and 75 to 90 grams of protein, which lets most women over sixty-five lose weight slowly while keeping their strength. If your doctor wants you at a different number, add or remove the starch and the afternoon snack first.

Every day, whatever the menu says: a glass of water with each meal and one between. Coffee or tea without sugar. A piece of fruit and a small handful of nuts in the afternoon. One square of dark chocolate after dinner, then the kitchen is closed.

Every Sunday: make Betty’s chicken soup or Audrey’s vegetable soup for the freezer, Martha’s roasted vegetable tray, Julia’s vinaigrette, and a dozen boiled eggs. That one hour makes the week easy.

Week 1: Sophia’s week

Day	Breakfast	Lunch	Dinner
Mon	Julia’s omelet with spinach, toast	Audrey’s vegetable soup, a boiled egg, bread	Sophia’s spaghetti al pomodoro with white beans, Neapolitan salad
Tue	Jane’s Greek yogurt bowl	Martha’s big salad with tuna	Sophia’s baked fish with tomatoes and olives, green beans
Wed	Scrambled eggs with tomato, toast	Pasta e fagioli	Jane’s chicken sheet pan, with bread
Thu	Greek yogurt bowl with a boiled egg	Leftover chicken chopped into a big salad	Audrey’s vegetable soup with cheese, bread
Fri	Omelet with cheese, sliced tomato	Cottage cheese plate	Sophia’s spaghetti with shrimp (add 4 ounces), salad
Sat	Baked eggs in greens, toast	Pasta e fagioli	Clint’s salmon with

Day	Breakfast	Lunch	Dinner
			vegetables, small sweet potato
Sun	Greek yogurt bowl	Julia’s roast chicken, roasted vegetables, salad	Chicken soup from the pot, bread

Week 1 shopping list. Eggs (18), plain Greek yogurt (large tub), cottage cheese, Parmesan, a block of cheese, 2 percent milk, butter. Chicken thighs or breasts (2 pounds) and a whole chicken. Two white fish fillets, two salmon fillets, 4 ounces shrimp, a can of tuna. Dry spaghetti, small pasta, whole-grain bread. Canned crushed tomatoes (2), diced tomatoes (3), white beans (3), chickpeas. Low-sodium broth (2 cartons). Olive oil, garlic, onions (4), carrots, celery, lemons (4), a bag of spinach, romaine, cucumber, tomatoes, cherry tomatoes, green beans, zucchini, sweet potato, baby potatoes, olives, fresh basil or dried. Berries (fresh or frozen), apples, oranges, walnuts or almonds, dark chocolate.

Week 2: Jane’s week

Day	Breakfast	Lunch	Dinner
Mon	Greek yogurt bowl	Jane’s red lentil soup with yogurt, bread	Jane’s salmon with greens, small potato
Tue	Omelet with leftover roasted vegetables	Cottage cheese plate	Clint’s stir-fry with chicken, brown rice
Wed	Scrambled eggs, toast	Lentil soup, a boiled egg	Martha’s lemon fish packet, roasted vegetables
Thu	Greek yogurt bowl	Martha’s big salad with chickpeas and egg	Jane’s chicken sheet pan with bread
Fri	Martha’s green smoothie with yogurt, a boiled egg	Clint’s sardines on toast, tomato	Sophia’s pasta e fagioli, salad
Sat	Baked eggs in greens	Leftover chicken salad	Betty’s hot dog night with slaw

Day	Breakfast	Lunch	Dinner
Sun	Omelet	Dolly’s chicken and dumplings, greens	Audrey’s La Paisible plate: cheese, egg, tomato, bread, fruit

Week 2 shopping list. Eggs (18), Greek yogurt, cottage cheese, cheese, milk, butter. Chicken (2 pounds) plus a whole chicken or thighs for the dumplings. Two salmon fillets, two white fish fillets, two cans sardines, a can of chickpeas. Red lentils, brown rice, flour, baking powder, whole-grain bread, hot dog buns, good hot dogs. Canned diced tomatoes, white beans, broth. Spinach, kale, cabbage for slaw, romaine, cucumber, tomatoes, carrots, celery, onions, bell pepper, zucchini, broccoli, asparagus or more zucchini, potatoes, lemons, ginger, apple. Berries, fruit, nuts, chocolate. Low-sodium soy sauce, cumin.

Week 3: Dolly’s week

Day	Breakfast	Lunch	Dinner
Mon	Scrambled eggs with	Dolly’s pinto beans with	Clint’s salmon with

Day	Breakfast	Lunch	Dinner
	vegetables, cornbread wedge	greens, cornbread	vegetables
Tue	Greek yogurt bowl	Betty’s chicken soup from the freezer	Jane’s chicken sheet pan, bread
Wed	Omelet	Pinto beans and greens with a boiled egg	Martha’s fish packet, roasted vegetables
Thu	Greek yogurt bowl with egg	Martha’s big salad with leftover chicken	Sophia’s spaghetti al pomodoro with beans, salad
Fri	Baked eggs in greens	Cottage cheese plate	Audrey’s chicken with lemon and herbs, potatoes, green beans
Sat	Smoothie with yogurt, boiled egg	Dolly’s tomato sandwich, cup of soup	Clint’s stir-fry with shrimp or tofu, rice
Sun	Omelet, cornbread	Julia’s roast chicken,	Light supper: soup and

Day	Breakfast	Lunch	Dinner
		roasted vegetables, salad	bread, then a small bowl of Dolly’s banana pudding

Week 3 shopping list. Eggs, Greek yogurt, cottage cheese, cheese, milk, buttermilk, butter. Chicken (2 pounds) and a whole chicken. Two salmon fillets, two white fish fillets, shrimp or tofu. Cornmeal, flour, spaghetti, rice, bread. Canned pinto beans (2), white beans, diced tomatoes, crushed tomatoes, broth, smoked turkey wing or turkey bacon. Collard greens or kale, spinach, romaine, tomatoes, cucumber, onions, carrots, celery, broccoli, zucchini, green beans, potatoes, baby potatoes, lemons, cider vinegar. For the pudding: instant vanilla pudding, vanilla wafers, bananas (3), whipped topping. Fruit, nuts, chocolate.

Week 4: Your week

By now you have twenty-six recipes and you know which ones you like. Build this week yourself with the five rules:

- **Breakfast:** eggs or Greek yogurt, every day, with fruit or a slice of toast.

- **Lunch:** a soup from the freezer, a big salad with protein, or the cottage cheese plate.
- **Dinner:** half vegetables, a palm of protein, a small starch. Fish twice this week. Beans twice. Chicken twice. One night of whatever you love, in Dolly’s spoonfuls.
- **Sunday:** cook the pot for next week.

Write it on the refrigerator on Saturday. Shop once. A written menu is the difference between the Hollywood plate and the toast-and-tea plate, and it takes ten minutes.

Chapter 12. Cooking for one, and the pantry that makes it easy

Most of the stars in this book cooked, or had cooked for them, in large kitchens for large tables. You may be cooking for one, in a small kitchen, with a bad knee. Here is how to make the menu work anyway.

Eight tricks for cooking for one

1. **Cook once, eat three times.** Every soup, the roast chicken, the sheet pan and the roasted tray are built to be eaten across the week. Cook on Sunday, portion into containers, and the weekday meal is three minutes in the microwave.
2. **Freeze in single portions.** Soup in one-cup containers or freezer bags laid flat. Cooked chicken in half-cup bags. Label with the date. Three months is fine.
3. **Boil a dozen eggs on Sunday.** They keep a week in the shell in the refrigerator and solve breakfast, lunch, and every salad.
4. **Buy frozen vegetables without shame.** They are picked ripe, cost less, and never go soft in the drawer. Keep spinach, green beans, broccoli, peas and a stir-fry mix in the freezer always.
5. **Buy canned fish and beans by the case.** Tuna, salmon, sardines, white beans, chickpeas, pintos,

lentils. A can of fish and a can of beans is a meal with 40 grams of protein and no cooking.

6. **A small nonstick skillet, a medium pot, and a sheet pan** are the only equipment this book needs. If your hands hurt, a small food processor for chopping and an electric can opener are worth every dollar.
7. **Set the table.** Even for one. A plate, a glass, a napkin, the radio. Sophia and Audrey never ate standing at the counter, and neither should you. Sitting down is how you eat slowly, and eating slowly is how you eat less.
8. **If you cannot cook some days, do not skip.** Greek yogurt and fruit. Cottage cheese and tomato. Sardines on toast. A boiled egg and cheese and an apple. All of them are a meal with protein, and all take two minutes.

The pantry

With these in the house, you can make most of this book without a shopping trip.

Shelf: olive oil, canned tomatoes, canned beans, canned tuna and salmon and sardines, red lentils, small pasta and spaghetti, brown rice, oats, low-sodium broth, dried herbs (oregano, thyme, rosemary, Italian seasoning), cumin, paprika, garlic, onions, potatoes, sweet potatoes, nuts, dark chocolate, honey, vinegar, Dijon mustard, low-sodium soy sauce.

Refrigerator: eggs, Greek yogurt, cottage cheese, a block of cheese, Parmesan, butter, milk, lemons, carrots, celery, a bag of greens, Julia’s vinaigrette in a jar.

Freezer: spinach, green beans, broccoli, peas, stir-fry mix, berries, chicken thighs, salmon or white fish fillets, shrimp, bread, and your own soups.

If you have a grandchild in the kitchen

Give them the cornbread, the banana pudding, the roast chicken to baste, and the omelet to flip. Every star in this

book learned to eat from a grandmother. You are the grandmother now.

At the Back of the Book

Recipes by occasion

Breakfast in five minutes: Julia's omelet · Jane's Greek yogurt bowl · Betty's scrambled eggs with vegetables · Martha's green smoothie · Martha's baked eggs in greens

A quiet supper for one: Clint's sardines on toast · Audrey's La Paisible plate · Jane's cottage cheese plate · Dolly's tomato sandwich · a bowl of soup from the freezer

Sunday with the grandchildren: Julia's roast chicken · Dolly's chicken and dumplings · Dolly's skillet cornbread · Dolly's banana pudding · Martha's cake, one slice

Something to bring to church or a neighbor: Dolly's pinto beans with greens · Audrey's vegetable soup · Sophia's pasta e fagioli · skillet cornbread

The pot for the week: Betty’s chicken soup · Audrey’s vegetable soup · Jane’s red lentil soup · Martha’s roasted vegetable tray · Julia’s vinaigrette

Fish nights: Sophia’s baked fish with tomatoes and olives · Jane’s salmon with greens · Martha’s lemon fish packet · Clint’s salmon and vegetables

The small indulgence: Betty’s hot dog night · Betty’s oven fries · Julia’s hamburger · Audrey’s square of chocolate · Clint’s fruit and nuts

Kitchen measures

- 1 cup = 8 fluid ounces = 16 tablespoons
- 1 tablespoon = 3 teaspoons
- “The size of your palm” = about 3 to 4 ounces of cooked meat or fish
- “A small handful” of nuts = about 1 ounce, 12 almonds or 7 walnut halves
- A 9-inch plate is the small plate. Measure yours.

- Oven: 400°F for fish and vegetables, 425°F for chicken and roasting

A note for your doctor

Take this page to your next appointment.

I am following a menu built on the Mediterranean pattern: about 1,400 to 1,600 calories a day, 75 to 90 grams of protein spread across three meals, half the plate vegetables, fish twice a week, beans twice a week, olive oil, little added sugar, and no more than one alcoholic drink a day. I am also doing light strength exercise two or three times a week. Is this appropriate for me, and is there anything I should change because of my medications or conditions, especially blood thinners, kidney function, diabetes, or blood pressure?

Foods in this book that can interact with common medicines: leafy greens and warfarin (keep the amount steady from day to day rather than avoiding them); grapefruit and many heart and cholesterol medicines;

alcohol and nearly everything. Your pharmacist can check your list in five minutes for free.

A last word

Sophia Loren is at the table. So is Audrey, and Julia, and Jane, and Betty with her hot dog, and Martha with her green glass, and Dolly with a spoonful of everything, and Clint with his salmon and his silence. Not one of them is on a diet. Every one of them eats real food, in a small portion, with pleasure, and gets up from the table and goes out to do something.

That is the Hollywood plate. It has been there all along.

If you cook one of these recipes and it becomes yours, tell us which one in the comments of any of our videos. And if there is a star whose kitchen you would like us to open, tell us that too.

The Behind the Fame team